

Islamic Thought and the Art of Translation

*Texts and Studies in Honor of William C. Chittick
and Sachiko Murata*

Edited by

Mohammed Rustom



BRILL

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*The author has no share save the post of translator, and no portion
but the trade of speaker.*

From the preface of Jāmī, *Lawā'ih*, trans. William C. Chittick in Sachiko
Murata, *Chinese gleams of Sufi light: Wang Tai-yü's* Great learning of the
pure and real and *Liu Chih's* Displaying the concealment of the real realm,
Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 2000, 134



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Being with a Capital B: Ibn Turka on Ibn ‘Arabī’s Lettrist Cosmogony

Matthew Melvin-Koushki

Back in graduate school, I regularly made the pilgrimage from New Jerusalem (aka New Haven) to Mount Sinai—in its Long Island manifestation—to read Ibn ‘Arabī (d. 638/1240) and Ibn Turka (d. 835/1432) with Professor Chittick, often followed by dinner and shisha. Even more than his oceanic erudition and that of Professor Murata, it was these encounters that helped form me as a scholar and philologist-to-the-death. Their bookhoard home is a magical portal onto an alternate, paradisaical, Qajar dimension; I remain awed and inspired by their total commitment to the beauty of the text. In honor of Professor Chittick and Professor Murata’s watershed scholarship and equally generous mentorship, I can think of no offering more meet than an investigation into Ibn Turka’s take on Ibn ‘Arabī’s take on *magical text*—or *text as magic*.



1 Introduction

Lettrism (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*) was a science central to both sages’ life projects.¹ Indeed, more than any of Ibn ‘Arabī’s innumerable commentators and intellectual heirs, Ibn Turka was responsible for the philosophical systematization and sociopolitical mainstreaming of this occult science, with sweeping ramifications for the history of science, the history of empire, and the history of the book alike. His *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam* is the first and only commentary on the Supreme Master’s most seminal work to be thoroughlygoingly lettrist in focus.² His *Book of investigations* (*Kitāb al-Maḥāṣiṣ*), the first summa

1 See, e.g., Gril, Denis, “The science of letters,” in Muḥyī al-Dīn Ibn al-‘Arabī, *The Meccan revelations*, ed. Michel Chodkiewicz, trans. Cyrille Chodkiewicz and Denis Gril, 2 vols., ii, New York: Pir Press, 2004, 105–219; Rašić, Dunja, *The written world of God: The cosmic script and the art of Ibn ‘Arabī*, Oxford: Anqa Publishing, 2021.

2 Melvin-Koushki, Matthew, *The quest for a universal science: The occult philosophy of Ṣā‘in*

of Islamic Pythagoreanism, definitively synthesizes, fully works out, and productively extends the lettrist implications littering Ibn ‘Arabi’s oeuvre, defined by the classic esotericizing principle of *tabdīd al-‘ilm*, ‘scattering knowledge,’ which principle he rejects.³ To make them scientifically and technologically usable to his royal patrons specifically and the scholarly community generally, Ibn Turka penned over a dozen Persian and Arabic books and treatises on lettrism, stylistically gorgeous, philosophically cutting-edge, and wonderfully accessible in a way no previous treatments had been.

This corpus exemplifies a new, specifically early modern sensibility, whereby the esoteric and elitist discourse of medieval and ancient thinkers was systematically de-esotericized and democratized in the service of empirical science and world empire.⁴ For Ibn Turka, lettrism is simultaneously the most valid form of metaphysics *and* physics, the epitome of *taḥqīq*, the ultimate proof of the superiority of the Moderns to the Ancients. The perennialist yet progressivist “lettrist consciousness” or “cosmic philology” this Isfahani occult philosopher fostered came to inform everything from Persianate riddle (*mu‘ammā*) culture to imperial architecture, to arts of the book. Most notably, it was an important engine of the *mathesis* turn that would define the “Scientific Revolution,” whereby Muslims, Jews, and Christians, respectfully departing from Aristotle and returning to Pythagoras, began to read and write the world as a mathematical, magical text.⁵

To give a taste (*dhawq*) of this transformative textual process, this Pythagorean paradigm shift, I offer a translation and brief contextualization of Ibn Turka’s Arabic treatise *On the B* (*al-Risāla al-Bā’iyya*). It was written in answer to a colleague’s question as to why *B* opens the Quran; that the same letter also opens the Torah made this question an equally pressing concern for Jewish and Christian kabbalists, and hence a productive site for comparative early mod-

al-Dīn Turka Isfahānī (1369–1432) and intellectual millenarianism in early Timurid Iran, New Haven (PhD Diss.): Yale University, 2012, 112–113. Professor Chittick, needless to say, served as a reader of my dissertation.

3 Melvin-Koushki, *The quest*, ch. 7; Gardiner, Noah D., *Esotericism in a manuscript culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and his readers through the Mamlūk period*, Ann Arbor (PhD Diss.): University of Michigan, 2014, ch. 2.

4 On this definition of early modernity see Melvin-Koushki, Matthew, “*Taḥqīq* vs. *taqlīd* in the renaissances of Western early modernity,” in *Philological Encounters* 3.1 (2018), 193–249.

5 Melvin-Koushki, Matthew, “Powers of One: The mathematicalization of the occult sciences in the High Persianate tradition,” in *IHIW* 5.1 (2017), 127–199. On this simultaneously mathematical and linguistic cosmology as a patrimony of Hellenistic late antiquity see Acevedo, Juan, *Alphanumeric cosmology from Greek into Arabic: The idea of stoicheia through the medieval Mediterranean*, Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2020.

ern Western intellectual historiography. In his own remarkable treatment of the subject, our Timurid lettrist does what he does best: he stitches together Ibn ‘Arabī’s freewheeling insights on the subject into a conceptually precise and usable product. Ibn Turka’s only other identified source is the Kubrawi shaykh Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamūya (d. 649/1252), Ibn ‘Arabī’s Iranian contemporary, whose oeuvre is even more centrally lettrist, and even more slippery. Indeed, Ḥamūya—who talismanically blessed the Ilkhanid ruler Ghāzān Khan’s (r. 694–703/1295–1304) conversion to Islam, prefiguring Ibn Turka’s own service to the Timurid dynasty—went so far as to personally criticize Ibn ‘Arabī in a letter as being too rigid in his lettrism!⁶ What this critique makes clear, however, is that both Ibn ‘Arabī and Ḥamūya can be usefully read as *jazz philosophers*—and Ibn Turka, their systematizing and Pythagoreanizing lettrist heir, as a *philosopher of jazz*.⁷

2 Betic Cosmogony in Premodern Lettrist and Kabbalist Thought

If you are indeed a teacher, and if you know the letters well,
tell me the power of *alpha* and I will tell you that of *beta*.

*The infancy gospel of Thomas*⁸

B is not among the light (*nūrānī*) letters—the 14 isolated letters (*muqatta‘āt*) opening 29 Sūras, naturally a primary matrix of lettrism, representing exactly half the Arabic alphabet—but rather first of the dark (*ẓulmānī*) ones and fountainhead of all duality. Why, then, does it open both the Quran and the Torah, those mathematical-linguistic models of the cosmos? Surely the primordial singularity of *A*, as avatar of both divine Oneness and the beginning of creation, is far better suited to this monotheistic, monotheurgic purpose?

This is the central cosmogonic conundrum Ibn Turka addresses in the *R. al-Bā‘iyya*. To riddle it, he deftly combines rational and traditional arguments in

6 See now Uy II, Cyril V., *Lost in a sea of letters: Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamūya (d. 1252) and the plurality of Sufi knowledge*, Providence (PhD Diss.): Brown University, 2021, 14, 89–91 and *passim*.

7 My thanks to Prof. Uy for this analogy. His masterful dissertation is the first on Ḥamūya, of equal importance to Ibn ‘Arabī in the history of lettrism. We eagerly await the critical edition of Ḥamūya’s seminal *Kitāb al-Maḥbūb*—one of Ibn Turka’s favorite sources—by Elizabeth Alexandrin and Paul Ballanfat. Jacques Derrida (d. 2004) has also been called a jazz philosopher, for equally obvious reasons; see, e.g., Ramshaw, Sara, *Justice as improvisation: The law of the extempore*, New York: Routledge, 2013, 111.

8 Translated in Acevedo, *Alphanumeric cosmology* 128.

the standard scholarly manner, drawing on Ibn ‘Arabī and Ḥamūya in particular, who drew in turn on centuries of Sufi speculation on the subject. Their eastern authorities include such luminaries as Sahl al-Tustarī (d. 282/896), al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī (d. ca. 295–300/907–912), Maṣṣūr al-Ḥallāj (d. 309/922), Abū Naṣr al-Sarrāj (d. 377/988) and Abū ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Sulamī (d. 412/1021); their western authorities include Ibn Masarra (d. 319/931) and Ibn Barrajān (d. 536/1141).⁹ Taken together, a recurring theme in these early lettrist speculations is the status of the dot (*nuqṭa*) under the *B* as ultimate symbol of divine creation.¹⁰ But their tenor is strictly allusive and alliterative, rather than philosophical or Pythagorean, with emphasis on the simple occurrence of the letter in various Arabic terms or divine names, and talismanic applications are not discussed. This approach is epitomized in Sulamī’s treatise *Explication of the meaning of the letters* (*Sharḥ ma‘ānī l-ḥurūf*), which synthesizes many earlier sources, usually without attribution:

The *Bā*’ ... symbolizes that through God (*bihi*) all things are brought forth and made to perish. It can also indicate that God is the Eternal (*al-abadī*) for whom eternity a parte ante (*azal*) and a parte post (*abad*) has no reality. This thought is illustrated by a verse of Abū ‘Alī al-Rūdhabārī, “You are troubled because He conceals from Himself His affection for you, hides from you His affection for you, and hides from you your affection for Him. Like a beam that flashes up from a beacon, He wanders aimlessly about in passionate love for you, unless you yourself are the flash.” The *Bā*’ can also signify the divine names that begin with the letter *Bā*’. With regard

9 On Ibn Barrajān and his doctrine of world as scripture see Casewit, Yousef, *The mystics of al-Andalus: Ibn Barrajān and Islamic thought in the twelfth century*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017. On Ibn Masarra, whose more philosophical, Neoplatonizing approach to the letters was an especially important model for Ibn ‘Arabī, see Garrido Clemente, Pilar, “The science of letters in Ibn Masarra: Unified word, unified world,” in *Journal of the Muhyiddin Ibn ‘Arabi Society* 47 (2010), 47–61; Ebstein, Michael, *Mysticism and philosophy in al-Andalus: Ibn Masarra, Ibn al-‘Arabī and the Ismā‘īlī tradition*, Leiden: Brill, 2014, ch. 2. The authorship of the two lettrist treatises attributed to Ibn Masarra in modern scholarship is not secure; however, as José Bellver has shown, Ibn ‘Arabī’s citation of his *Kitāb al-Ḥurūf*, aka *al-Lisān al-‘aẓīm fī l-ḥurūf*—presumably a different work—confirms him as an important lettrist authority in any case (see Bellver, José, “The beginnings of rational theology in al-Andalus: Ibn Masarra and his refutation of al-Kindī’s *On first philosophy*,” in *Qanṭara* 41.2 (2020), 323–371).

10 This summary is given in Böwering, Gerhard, “Sulamī’s treatise on the science of the letters (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*),” in Bilal Orfali (ed.), *In the shadow of Arabic: The centrality of language to Arabic culture. Studies presented to Ramzi Baalbaki on the occasion of his sixtieth birthday*, Leiden: Brill, 2011, 339–397, 352.

to human beings, the *Bā'* refers to them as God's servants who follow His commands with loyalty and zeal or, in the words of Ibn 'Aṭā', it manifests God's kindness (*birr*) toward the prophets.¹¹

A similarly allusive approach to the *B* features in the earliest texts of kabbalah, which also synthesize eastern and western authorities. The *Sefer ha-Bahir* (*Book of illumination*) is a case in point: it too dwells on the *B* in relation to the *A* as cosmogonic agent. As Elliot Wolfson summarizes in his analysis of this key medieval Hebrew work: "Before *alef* comes *beit*—here in a nutshell lies the wisdom of kabbalah."¹² This paradoxical principle became a central focus of subsequent kabbalist meditations on the mechanics of creation, reaching a crescendo in the Italian Renaissance with such systematizing humanist scholars as Rabbi Yohanan Alemanno (d. after 1504) and his student Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (d. 1494), father of Christian kabbalah.¹³ These meditations pivot on the concept of the *coincidentia oppositorum* as famously formalized by the German Pythagorean cardinal Nicholas of Cusa (d. 1464): the *B* as 2 is both the engine of duality and the tool for return to singularity through the marriage of all opposites.¹⁴

The same concept runs like a red thread through Ibn 'Arabī's vast, kaleidoscopic oeuvre and gives it a measure of thematic coherence, as Professor Chittick and Professor Murata have definitively shown. To this end, he frequently invokes the classic Sufi—and Empedoclean and Plotinian—phrase *al-nikāḥ al-sāri fī jamī' al-dharārī*, 'the marriage act pervading all atoms,' to explain the mechanics of creation.¹⁵ And what is more atomic than the dot under the *B*? For it is the origin of all letters, even the *A*, composed of three dots.

11 Böwering, "Sulamī's treatise" 357.

12 Wolfson, Elliot R., *Alef, mem, tau: Kabbalistic musings on time, truth, and death*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006, 118.

13 On both figures see especially Ogren, Brian, *The beginning of the world in renaissance Jewish thought: Ma'aseh Bereshit in Italian Jewish philosophy and kabbalah, 1492–1535*, Leiden: Brill, 2016.

14 Albertson, David, *Mathematical theologies: Nicholas of Cusa and the legacy of Thierry of Chartres*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014, *passim*.

15 Indeed, one of Ibn 'Arabī's lost works bears precisely this title. On this and related themes see, of course, Murata, Sachiko, *The Tao of Islam: A sourcebook on gender relationships in Islamic thought*, Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 1992, 147–151 and *passim*; Chittick, William C., *The Sufi path of knowledge: Ibn al-'Arabī's metaphysics of imagination*, Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 1989, ch. 20; Chittick, William C., *The self-disclosure of God: Principles of Ibn al-'Arabī's cosmology*, Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 1998, 5–6, 173–181. Its most salient precedent would seem to be Plotinus's (d. 270) doctrine of *erotic-cum-numeric* emanation of the many from the transcendent One, well known to arabophone philosophers through the pseudepigraphal

What the perceptive reader might glean from Ibn ‘Arabī’s scattered treatments of the letters generally and *A* and *B* specifically, especially in his monumental *Meccan revelations* (*al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya*), is that the latter letter is intimately connected to his (in)famous theory of the superiority of *walāya* to *nubuwwa*, of sainthood to prophethood.¹⁶ While a stumblingblock for more puritan scholars, this theory became hegemonic by the early modern period, and indeed the basis for radical new theories of saint-philosopher-kingship that defined post-Mongol Persianate imperial discourse, whether Mughal, Safavid, or Ottoman.¹⁷ As preeminent theoretician of human sainthood generally and Islamic sainthood specifically, Ibn ‘Arabī identified Jesus as Seal or ultimate model of the first, and himself as Seal of the second.¹⁸ But many of his otherwise faithful intellectual heirs, both Sunni and Shi‘i, begged to differ with the Doctor Maximus on this point, arguing instead for the historical superiority of ‘Alid sainthood to Muḥammadan prophecy—in precisely betic terms.

The first to do so was Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī (d. ca. 787/1385), who combined lettrist, astrological, and alchemical proofs to demonstrate the identity of Sufism and Shi‘ism.¹⁹ Central to his cosmogonic argument is the *B*: graphically a straight line indistinguishable from the *A*, its distinguishing lower dot rep-

Theology of Aristotle (*Uthūlūjīyā*), a partial translation of the *Enneads*. The Empedoclean doctrine of Love and Strife similarly informed Suhrawardī’s (d. 587/1191) Illuminationist philosophy. See Banner, Nicholas, *Philosophic silence and the ‘One’ in Plotinus*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2018, *passim*; Walbridge, John, *The leaven of the ancients: Suhrawardī and the heritage of the Greeks*, Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 2000, 48–51.

- 16 Contrary to Ibn ‘Arabī’s usual scattering procedure, the long second chapter of the *Futūḥāt* is mostly lettrist in tenor; for translated sections, see Gril, “The science of letters;” Ibn al-‘Arabī, Muḥyī al-Dīn, *The openings revealed in Makkah* (*al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyyah*): *Books 1 and 2*, trans. Eric Winkel, New York: Pir Press, 2018, 161–324. For a summary of his cosmology more generally see Chittick, William C., *Ibn ‘Arabī: Heir to the prophets*, Oxford: Oneworld, 2005. On Ḥamūya’s equivocal, cyclic approach to the same question see Alexandrin, Elizabeth R., “Seals and sealing of *walāyah* in Šūfī and Shi‘ī texts: The cases of al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī and Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamūyah,” in Saiyad Nizamuddin Ahmad and Sajjad H. Rizvi (eds.), *Philosophy and the intellectual life in Shī‘ah Islam*, London: The Shī‘ah Institute Press, 2017, 69–93; Uy, “Lost in a sea of letters,” ch. 4.
- 17 Melvin-Koushki, Matthew, “Early modern Islamicate empire: New forms of religiopolitical legitimacy,” in Armando Salvatore et al. (eds.), *The Wiley-Blackwell history of Islam*, Hoboken: Wiley-Blackwell, 2018, 353–375.
- 18 See, e.g., Elmore, Gerald T., *Islamic sainthood in the fullness of time: Ibn al-‘Arabī’s Book of the fabulous gryphon*, Leiden: Brill, 1999, *passim*.
- 19 Mansouri, Mohammad Amin, “*Walāya* between lettrism and astrology: The occult mysticism of Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī (d. c. 787/1385),” in *Journal of Sufi Studies* 9.2 (2020), 161–201.

resents the transformation of Creator into created. As such, the second letter is the first being, “which is called Intellect, Spirit, Pen, Substance, Light, Element, Cause, Isthmus, Presence of Oneness, Presence of Names, First Entification, First Manifestation, Caliph, and First Imam.”²⁰

For the Twelver Shi‘i sage Āmulī, the *B* thus represents prophethood, and its dot sainthood, without which the eternal divine effluxion must remain cosmically unmanifest. Hence the saying of the First Imam himself, ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib (d. 40/661): “I am the dot beneath the *B* (*anā l-nuqṭa allatī taḥt al-bā*).” Here Āmulī takes Ibn ‘Arabī to task for failing to correctly ascribe to ‘Alī this seminal tradition, which served as proof-text for all later lettrists, regardless of confessional affiliation.²¹

So much for theory; what of practice? While a cosmogonist in his own right, the Sufi sage-mage Aḥmad al-Būnī (d. btw. 622–630/1225–1232) came to epitomize applied lettrism from the 9th/15th century onward, in contrast with the theoretical lettrism of Ibn ‘Arabī, due not least to the categorizing efforts of Ibn Turka. The Andalusian lettrist famously swore not to practice his art; his Ifriqiyan counterpart swore no such thing.²² Al-Būnī’s treatments of the *B* therefore combine both theory and practice, though later Būnian pseudepigrapha—especially the *Great sun of knowledge* (*Shams al-ma‘ārif al-kubrā*), a grimoire even more ubiquitous in Islamdom than Maslama al-Qurṭubī’s (d. 353/964) bestselling *Goal of the sage* (*Ghāyat al-ḥakīm*), aka the Latin *Picatrix*—reflect his reception as Ibn ‘Arabī’s complement and twin, and so are more resolutely technological. As that may be, both theory and practice are on display in his *Subtle allusions* (*Laṭā‘if al-ishārāt*), an authentic work.²³ Therein he first provides and explicates this cosmogonic diagram of the *B*, graphically representing the lettrist theory al-Būnī shares with Ibn ‘Arabī—

20 For the technical terms in this passage and their significance see the translation in Mansouri, “*Walāya*” 183.

21 Mansouri, “*Walāya*” 189–190. On Āmulī’s complex diagrams of his lettrist cosmogony and cosmology see Viengkhou, Aaron, “*Tawḥīd* divided: The esoteric orthodoxy of Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī (d. after 782/1380),” in *La Rosa di Paracelso* 2 (2020 [2022]), 27–51; Viengkhou, Aaron, “Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī’s scripturalization of reality,” in *IOSOTR*, http://islamicoccult.org/aaron_viengkhou (last accessed: 25 October 2021). Cf. Winters, Zach, “Reading the Book of Creation in the *Miftāḥ al-Asrār* of Āzarī Isfarāyīnī,” in *La Rosa di Paracelso* 2 (2020 [2022]), 13–25.

22 As Dunja Rašić shows, however, several talismanic diagrams nevertheless occur in his oeuvre (*The written world*).

23 Gardiner, *Esotericism*, *passim*. For an (unreliable) edition of the *Laṭā‘if al-ishārāt* see Coulon, Jean-Charles, *La magie islamique et le corpus bunianum au Moyen Âge*, 4 vols., iv, Paris (PhD Diss.): University of Paris IV—Sorbonne, 2013, 64–180/394.

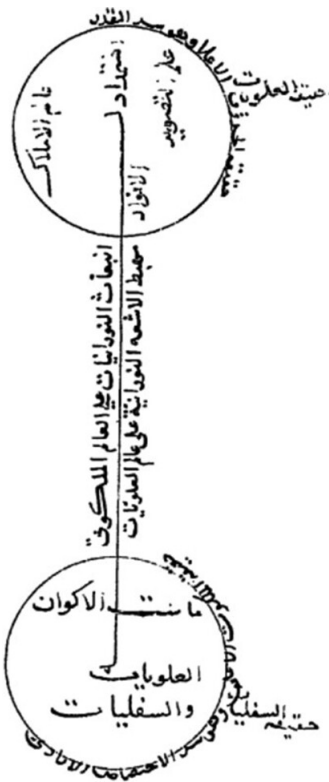


FIGURE 9.1
B diagram in al-Būnī, *Laṭā'if al-ishārāt*, Paris, BnF, Ms
Arabe 2657, f. 28^a
REPRODUCED IN COULON, “LA MAGIE ISLAMIQUE”
IV, 103/394, FIG. 23

note the letter’s representation as a second *A* joining the celestial realm to the terrestrial (see Fig. 9.1 above). He then details its practical applications—including medical—as follows:

Know that whoever writes this form [of the *B*] on a Friday, fasting on Thursday as well as Friday and giving alms, then binds it to his right upper arm, God shall open his breast and, having removed all lassitude, show him the secret inherent in the *B* and its angelic radiances. Therefore understand what the leading authorities have discoursed on with respect to the *B*—i.e., the letter itself—as to the fact that its formal manifestations, both supernal and infernal, together manifest an individual upright figure perfect of form and gorgeous of scent. As such, there is no authority that has not discoursed on the *B*, whose radiance is perpetual and unwavering. Upon any mention of its secret that radiance shines upon its essence, which essence inheres in certain divine names whose meaning is safely preserved, so that no motion is possible to it except through [the names of] God Most High. When this letter occurs in a divine

name it therefore serves as a conduit of divine grace to its user. Writing such a divine name [in order to wear it] is particularly useful [for easing] pains caused by [an excess of] dryness or easing any difficult undertaking, for God Most High will thereby ease it. These names of God Most High include the Kind (*al-birr*), the Creator (*al-bāri*), the Perduring (*al-bāqī*), and the Resurrector (*al-bā'ith*).²⁴

This is the context and sourcebase for Ibn Turka's synthetic, systematic treatise on the *B*. Focused on lettrist theory only, it is profoundly Akbarian (and Ḥamūyan) in tenor, as are most of his other lettrist works. Indeed, as noted, Ibn Turka is responsible for the overneat identification of Ibn 'Arabī with lettrist theory and al-Būnī with lettrist practice that would become standard thereafter.²⁵ Yet his partially successful quest to transform his Timurid warlord patrons into philosopher-kings made him a powerful advocate of its practice too, such as in his *Query of kings* (*Su'l al-mulūk*), which sets forth a full system of imperial talismanic lettrism, with medical, military, and other applications.²⁶

But to synthesize and systematize is also to create and contest.²⁷ All four operations are on display here as elsewhere in Ibn Turka's oeuvre. A committed Sunni imamophile and perennialist-progressivist, he embraces Ibn 'Arabī's doctrine of the superiority of sainthood to prophethood—but in his *On the dot* (*Risāla-yi Nuqṭa*) follows Āmulī in declaring Imam 'Alī the avatar of the dot under the *B* and epitome of Muḥammadan *walāya*.²⁸ The introduction

24 Coulon, *La magie islamique* iv, 102–104/394 (translation mine).

25 This most explicitly in his *Risāla-yi Hurūf*, which proposes an *ahl-i haqāyiq* vs. *ahl-i khawāṣṣ* binary, the latter group of practical lettrists being the majority; see Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 278–279, 478–479.

26 This work is edited and translated in my forthcoming *The lettrist treatises of Ibn Turka: Persian Pythagoreanism and imperial occultism in the Timurid renaissance*, Leiden: Brill (forthcoming).

27 Cf. the equally lettrist but encyclopedic project of Ibn Turka's Anatolian counterpart, 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Baṣṭāmī (d. 858/1454), on which see Gardiner, Noah D., "The occultist encyclopedism of 'Abd al-Raḥmān al-Baṣṭāmī," in *MSR* 20 (2017), 3–38. On early modern Islamic commentary culture as often creative and subversive rather than merely scholastic and imitative see, e.g., Ingalls, Matthew B., *The anonymity of a commentator: Zakariyyā al-Anṣārī and the rhetoric of Muslim commentaries*, Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 2021; Melvin-Koushki, "Tahqīq vs. taqlīd."

28 Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 344; for an edition and translation see my forthcoming *The lettrist treatises*. He expands on this point in the same treatise, citing Ḥamūya's *Kitāb al-Maḥbūb* (Tehran, MS Majlis 10196/10, f. 125^{a-b}):

[W]alāya refers to the dot under the *B*. This is demonstrated through the fact that the dot here under discussion has two aspects in its written form. First, it is the point of

to his *Book of investigations* is even more explicit on this point: it celebrates ‘Alī as the inventor of lettrism, a Muslim Pythagoras standing to Muḥammad as the Samoan sage did to Solomon. His mathematizing marriage of lettrism with Pythagoreanism by this device and others—centered on the doctrine of the *coincidentia oppositorum*—is likewise unprecedented, yet also calculated to fully Islamicize the Pythagorean project of the original Brethren of Purity (Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’), with whom he and his wide network of students strongly identified.²⁹

Two passages suffice to show his Pythagoreanizing approach to lettrism as enshrined in his *R. al-Bā’iyya*. From the *Book of investigations*:

Although multiplicity is fully expressed by 9, which comprises the totality of its degrees, its power and virtue first erupt in 2: for only in 2 is multiplicity pure, untainted by any other “unitness” whether actually or through comprehensive ascription that, commixed, would make it 3, which does not concern us here. No other number has this property, since all other numbers have a merely relative, comprehensive unitness and unitive, uniting form, which is as distant as possible from the originary 1, which is yet intimately joined thereto.

Twain is twain, and nothing but them remain:
a true saying—or rather, the finest wine!

B signifies this 2. It is the terminus of [numerical] relations and yet their very origin, as was discussed above. It is likewise that which combines firstness with coupling as the *coincidentia oppositorum* (*mu’tanaq al-*

origin of all insofar as it is a dot, which is the origin of all letterforms, as the author of [the *Book of the*] *Beloved* sings:

One dot became an *A* and *A* became all the letters
and so *A* occurs in each of their names.

Second, it is the point of return of all insofar as it is the cause of knowledge of its own characteristics and the source for distinguishing between all ambiguities. The consequence in this context is that *sacral power* refers to the origin of perception and witnessing of a one that is singular in its [expression of] true Oneness, just as the circumference of a circle is both point of origin and of return.

29 See, e.g., Melvin-Koushki, Matthew, “The New Brethren of Purity: Ibn Turka and the renaissance of Pythagoreanism in the early modern Persian cosmopolis,” in *IHIW* 11 (2023), forthcoming. It must be noted, however, that Ḥaydar Āmulī does gesture in the same direction, twice citing Pythagoras by way of the Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’, albeit in passing; see Viengkhou, “Scripturalization of reality.”

aḍḍād), one of the properties peculiar to the Prophet wherewith his heirs, “men of main and vision” [Q 38:45], provision themselves.³⁰

And from *On the dot* (his imamophilic citation of ‘Alī is here significant):

It will be clear to those who understand lettrist allusions that it is established on the pages of numerological analysis that *B* refers to the first entification, also known as the Muḥammadan Reality, this being clear by way of the connecting ties of correspondence. For the *coincidence of opposites* (*ta’ānuq-i aṭrāf*)—one of the features that most distinguishes this exalted Presence, as has been sung:

For me opposites embrace, the rug of otherness
rolled away: all things are equal.³¹

Devotedly, my lover closes a door she never opened,
cuts the cord of a friendship already severed.
Alas that her arrival that never happened never will!
Alack that she broke her false pledge!

—becomes most explicit on this level and here is most realized, insofar as it is the level of *secondness*, and as such the closest possible to and hence ultimate level after the One, as discussed in [my *Book of*] *investigations*. This is a thing so evident as to not admit of the slightest doubt. Thus the dot beneath it refers to the true Oneness that is the occult aspect of that entification and its reality, which can be neither the referent of any statement nor the import of any allusion. For as the Commander [of the Faithful] himself said in his answer to the questions of Kumayl: “[Ultimate reality] is the revealing of the glories of [divine] Majesty [directly], without allusion.”³²

30 *Mafāḥiṣ*, 1.12, Tehran, MS Majlis 10196/2, ff. 62^a–b. Ibn Turka clarifies in his *Risāla-yi Shaqq al-qamar wa-bayān-i sā‘at* that this category refers in the first place to the House of the Prophet (*ahl-i bayt*), including the Twelve Imams and their Sufi heirs. It is likewise significant that his fellow Timurid Sunni imamophile lettrist, Ḥusayn Vā‘iz Kāshifī, quotes from the *Mafāḥiṣ* verbatim precisely on the *B* in his own thoroughlygoingly lettrist *Jawāhir al-tafsīr*. See Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 264–266, 315–320.

31 Ibn Turka often cites this line (227) from Ibn al-Fārid’s (d. 632/1235) *al-Tāḥya al-kubrā*, famed as “The poem of the way” (*Naẓm al-sulūk*), on which he wrote a full, prosimetric commentary, *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-durar*; see Melvin-Koushki, *The quest*, excursus.

32 Tehran, MS Majlis 10196/10, f. 125^a.

Ibn Turka's most radical departure from Sufi lettrist precedent, however, is in his valorization of the written and mathematical letter over the spoken.³³ Mapping Ibn 'Arabī's cosmology onto contemporary social, political, and scientific reality, in which book culture defined scholarly accreditation and affiliation, and mathematical occult science was booming, he pursued imperial and scholarly objectives foreign to those of his esotericizing sources.

Most subversively, he recast lettrism in Illuminationist terms in order to formally displace both Peripatetic and Illuminationist philosophy as the supreme form of metaphysics. Ironically, however, his challenge to Illuminationism in particular only served to integrate lettrism into the same. Preeminent *ishrāqī* philosophers like Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī (d. 908/1502) and Mīr Dāmād (d. 1040/1631) influentially embraced Ibn Turka's lettrist metaphysics, which synthesizes the Avicennan-Ṭūsian doctrine of the transcendental modulation of being (*tashkīk al-wujūd*) with its Suhravardian upgrade, the transcendental modulation of light (*tashkīk al-nūr*), to produce his signature doctrine of the transcendental modulation of letter (*tashkīk al-ḥarf*): letters of light as uncreated, all-creative matrix of the cosmos, gradually descending from the One in extramental, mental, spoken, and finally written form. This doctrine is the most philosophically robust defense of the book and the book arts in Islamic intellectual history—and imperial architecture by extension. As I have argued, its Pythagorean project was most fully embodied in the design schemes of the Shaykh Luṭf Allāh Mosque in Isfahan, the new Safavid capital city itself and the Tāj Maḥal in Mughal Agra, those epitomes of the Timurid imperial mode.³⁴

Ibn Turka's lettrist metaphysics-physics likewise served as a fitting preface to the 9th/15th-century boom in book culture and encyclopedism throughout the Islamic heartlands. Arabic and Persian manuals on a panoply of sciences—occult or otherwise—proliferated expressly as a means to relieve the reader of the need for a teacher. The era of *deep reading* had begun.³⁵ Exemplifying this new, early modern culture, his own Arabic and Persian manuals of

33 Here again, however, his departure does have Shī'ī precedent: Ḥaydar Āmulī and even Nāṣir-i Khusraw (d. 481/1088) both make a similar intervention, although less explicitly and systematically. See Mansouri, "Walāya"; Mansouri, *Spiritual hierarchy*. On the later Persianate reception of this revised lettrist hierarchy see, e.g., Cole, Juan, "The world as text: Cosmologies of Shaykh Ahmad al-Aḥsa'i," in *SI* 80 (1994), 145–163, 145–146.

34 Melvin-Koushki, Matthew, "Of Islamic grammatology: Ibn Turka's lettrist metaphysics of light," in *al-'Uṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 24 (2016), 46–117.

35 El-Rouayheb, Khaled, "The rise of 'deep reading' in early modern Ottoman scholarly culture," in Sheldon Pollock, Benjamin A. Elman, and Kuming Kevin Chang (eds.), *World philology*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2015, 201–224.

lettrism, several of which enjoyed wide popularity across the Persianate world, are unprecedentedly user-friendly, designed to train their readers—especially royal readers—in the science.

With such works as the *R. al-Bā'iyya* as precedent, the lettrist manuals produced during the 9th/15th and 10th/16th centuries are likewise accessible and systematic. They include those of the Aqqyunlu philosopher Davānī, the Timurid polymath Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī (d. 910/1505) and his son 'Alī Ṣafī (d. 939/1533). The latter's *Amulet of protection from the trials of time* (*Ḥirz al-amān min fitan al-zamān*), written for the Qizilbash governor of Khurasan, represents a summa of political lettrism; it became a bestseller during the high Safavid period, despite its dependence on Sunni authorities only—including Ibn Turka.³⁶ That his Sunni imamophilic brand of philosophical-scientific lettrism became a prime means of Shi'izing Iran under the Safavids is best seen in the oeuvre of Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī (fl. 985/1576), the most prolific Persian author on applied lettrism of the 10th/16th century, and teacher in the occult sciences to Shaykh Bahā'ī (d. 1030/1621) himself, the sage-mage architect of the Safavid state. Similarly drawing on al-Būnī and Ibn 'Arabī by way of Āmulī and Ibn Turka, Dihdār's works are studded with theoretical mediations on the *B*, as in this passage from his Twelverizing prosimetric treatise *Unveiling secrets* (*Kashf al-asrār*), in encomium to the First Imam:

For 'Alī ($LY = 110 > 11 > 2 > B$) is two 1s as shown by this *B*
 whose dot manifests therefrom.
 When the two 1s are properly joined
 they become wholly one in form:
 any who beholds its form
 must immediately count it the letter *B*,
 for the dot beneath it
 removes the veil of that letter.
 How wondrous to witness this—
 these two manifesting in existence as one!
 Two become one to manifest two 1s,
 thereby moving multiplicity to unveil herself.
 Oneness sits veiled in the *A*
 while manyness shows her face in the *B*—

36 Subtelný, Maria, "Kāshifī's *Asrār-i qāsimī*: A late Timurid manual of the occult sciences and its Safavid afterlife," in Liana Saif et al. (eds.), *Islamicate occult sciences in theory and practice*, Leiden: Brill, 2020, 267–313; Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 248–280.

yet it is the dot that is [primordial] Oneness
that manifests so mightily to distinguish the B!³⁷

Dihdār's thoroughlygoingly lettrist project does much to explain the status of Safavid philosophers like Ghiyās al-Dīn Maṣṣūr Dashtakī (d. 949/1542) and Shaykh Bahā'ī as master talismanists in service to the Safavid Empire, as well as the transformation of Ibn Sīnā (d. 428/1037) himself—no booster of the occult sciences—into a Pythagoreanizing occultist in the early 11th/17th century. It is likewise largely responsible for the sudden explosion in popularity of Rajab al-Bursī's (d. after 813/1411) *Dawnings of the lights of certain knowledge* (*Mashāriq anwār al-yaqīn*), a controversial work that, for all its Twelver theological extremism, draws on the same Akbarian lettrist lineage.³⁸

That Ibn Turka's lettrism successfully entered the Persianate philosophical mainstream is best seen in the oeuvre of Mīr Dāmād, which features no less than three lettrist works. Chief among them is *Firebrands and epiphanies* (*Jazavāt va-mavāqīt*), an ornate Persian summary of his Illuminationist philosophy as a whole, commissioned by Shāh 'Abbās the Great (r. 995–1038/1587–1629). By contrast, his Arabic *Lamp of illumination and keeping the balance* (*Nibrās al-ḍiyyā' wa-taswā' al-sawā'*) is focused on a thorny Twelver theological problem, the question of apparent change in the divine will (*badā'*): it deploys lettrist theory as the best means of riddling his signature doctrine of perpetual creation or meta-time (*ḥudūth dahri*), which he proposed as a new philosophy of history. (This proposal was directly inspired by Ibn Turka's own promotion of a new Pythagorean imperial historiography, enshrined in the *Book of conquest* (*Zafar-nāma*) of Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī (d. 858/1454), his closest friend and student. Combining lettrism and conjunction astrology, it became a model for persophone historians down to the colonial period. Its basic premise: history can be a *science*³⁹). Here Mīr Dāmād's succinct treatment of the B—that engine of creation—characteristically reframes the ontological function of this letter in Avicennan-Illuminationist terms:

37 Tehran, MS Milli 12653/4, ff. 152^{a-b}.

38 Subtelný, "Kāshifī's *Asrār-i qāsimī*"; Lawson, Todd, "A 14th century Shi'ī gnostic: Rajab Bursī and his *Mashāriq al-anwār*," in *Ishraq: Islamic Philosophy Yearbook* 1 (2010), 422–438; Melvin-Koushki, Matthew, "World as (Arabic) text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of philosophy in Safavid Iran," in *SI* 114.3 (2019), 130–183; Melvin-Koushki, "Maḥmud Dehdār Širāzi," *Elr*.

39 On this new classificatory ethos more generally, peculiar to 9th/15th-century Persian and Arabic historiography, see Markiewicz, Christopher, "History as science: The fifteenth-century debate in Arabic and Persian," in *Journal of Early Modern History* 21 (2017), 216–240.

The degree of *B* is the spirit of twoness: it is the mate of the first and first of the repetitions of oneness. Its written form as ب is the first permutation and self-manifestation of ل, leading back thereto in its degree of precision, the supreme form of explication. As such, this letter was designated that of the realm of the intellect, indeed the First Intellect itself, chief of all things created. It is likewise the first of seconds, the Supreme Pen, the Right Hand—and the two extended hands of the All-merciful (whose power is exalted) are both right.

That its essence is at base the coupling of separating multiplicity and the doubling of the bond that is “the marriage act between all atoms”—as is signified in the holy revelation by the Most High’s saying “And of everything We created pairs, that haply you may remember” [Q 51:49]—can only be understood according to two senses, potential or actual, whereby the essential freedom of the substance of the essence (*dhāt*) itself becomes constrained by the other with respect to the actual effluxion of the doer; according to two degrees, quiddity (*māhiyya*) or quod-dity (*inniyya*); and according to two respects, genus or species, which twain constitute a quiddity, whose Creator is the Constituter (His mention be glorious) through His own essence, which is exclusive Oneness (*aḥadiyya*)—sole Actor and end of all action, Origin and Return, First and Last.⁴⁰

Space does not allow us to follow the many further iterations and evolutions of Ibn ‘Arabian, Ḥamūyan, Būnian, and Ibn Turkian lettrist theory on the *B* after the 11th/17th century; suffice it to say that, in Iran alone, the Shaykhiyya and Bābī and Baha’ī movements of the 19th century were all profoundly lettrist and indeed often talismanic in tenor.⁴¹ What the above examples show, however, is the remarkable degree to which Ibn Turka succeeded in making lettrist metaphysics and physics philosophically coherent and scientifically and politically usable over the long term.

This he did in the teeth of inquisition and intrigue, as the present treatise’s preface attests. It was written to combat the “baseless constructs and devious

40 Mir Dāmād, *Nibrās al-dīyā’ wa-taswā’ al-sawā’ fī sharḥ bāb al-badā’ wa-ithbāt jadwā l-du’ā*, with glosses by Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī, ed. Ḥamid Nājī Iṣfahānī, Tehran: Hijrat, 1995, 81–82; see Terrier, Mathieu, “The wisdom of God and the tragedy of history: The concept of appearance (*badā’*) in Mir Dāmād’s *Lantern of brightness*,” in Saiyad Nizamuddin Ahmad and Sajjad H. Rizvi (eds.), *Philosophy and the intellectual life in Shī‘ah Islam*, London: The Shī‘ah Institute Press, 2017, 94–133; Melvin-Koushki, “World as (Arabic) text.”

41 For references see Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 280–281.

propagandizing” of the contemporary Sufi Ḥurūfiyya movement in particular, whose anti-Timurid anarchism threatened his life’s project. Its longer-lived Nuqtavī offshoot represented a similar threat.⁴² At the same time, such movements reflected the new salience of lettrism among scholarly and political elites and the general populace alike throughout the early modern Persianate world, for whom Ibn Turka’s theory of the letter as light and light as being simply made cultural and cosmogonical sense.⁴³

3 Ibn Turka, Imperialist-Empiricist Philosopher of Akbarian Jazz

The first modern scholars to recognize the centrality of lettrism to Ibn Turka’s life’s project, Professor Muḥammad-Taqī Dānishpazhūh (d. 1996) and Ayatollah Sayyid ‘Alī Mūsawī Bihbahānī (d. 1975), made a strong case for his importance within the history of Western philosophy, and hence the need to finally edit and publish his oeuvre.⁴⁴ Dānishpazhūh even styled him the “Spinoza of Iran” to jumpstart research on this front. This presentation of one of Ibn Turka’s minor lettrist treatises is in modest answer to their call. But he was hardly a Spinoza (d. 1677), putative father of biblical criticism.

While certainly a monist in the Akbarian mode, Ibn Turka was no Quranic critic. To the contrary, he vehemently championed the Quran as blueprint for reality, departing, sometimes radically, from philosophical and mystical precedent in his systematic reformulation of lettrism as a simultaneously Pythagorean and ‘Alid universal science—and technology of universal empire. As such, he is comparable instead to the infamous Anglo-Welsh occultist John

42 See, e.g., Bashir, Shahzad, *Fazlallah Astarabadi and the Hurufis*, Oxford: Oneworld, 2005; Mir-Kasimov, Orkhan, *Words of power: Hurūfī teachings between Shi’ism and Sufism in medieval Islam. The original doctrine of Faḍl Allāh Astarābādī*, London: I.B. Tauris/Institute of Ismaili Studies, 2015; Babayan, Kathryn, *Mystics, monarchs and messiahs: Cultural landscapes of early modern Iran*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2002; Kiyā, Šādiq, *Nuqtaviyān yā Pasikhāniyān*, Tehran: Anjuman-i Īrānvīj, 1941. As Uy observes, however, the even more radical Ḥurūfī embrace of sheer linguistic play can be seen as an organic continuation of Ḥamūya’s project as well (*Lost in a sea of letters* 223).

43 That this “lettrist consciousness” permeated the Persianate world even through the colonial and reformist period is suggested by Pickett, James, *Polymaths of Islam: Power and networks of knowledge in Central Asia*, Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2020; Morgan, Daniel J., *Spokesman of the unseen world: Shāh Wali Allāh (1703–1762), Islamic reform and applied cosmology in late-Mughal Delhi*, Chicago (PhD Diss.): University of Chicago, 2021; Zadeh, Travis, *Wonders and rarities: The marvelous book that traveled the world and mapped the cosmos*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press (forthcoming).

44 For references see Melvin-Koushki, *The quest* 21.

Dee (d. 1608), model of Faust, who sought to weaponize Cusanus's *coincidentia oppositorum* for similarly imperial-scientific, kabbalist-alchemical purposes.⁴⁵

In broader Western intellectual-historical terms, his project is likewise reminiscent of those of other, far better studied Latin Christian scholars, like Pico and Giordano Bruno (d. 1600), and Jewish ones, like Alemanno, kabbalists to a man: they too called for the investigation of the world as another mathematical-linguistic scripture.⁴⁶ But none of them served sovereigns of the caliber of Ulugh Beg (r. 811–853/1409–1449), the most famous sultan-scientist in Islamic history, whose Samarkand Observatory—founded the same year, 823/1420, that Ibn Turka completed his *Book of investigations*—produced the most accurate star tables of the 9th/15th century, so accurate that they were still being used in London in the 19th. This epochal push for mathematical precision in astronomy has not a little to do with Ibn Turka's dedication to Ulugh Beg of his book-length lettrist analysis of the *basmala*, whose preface explicitly fashions him as saint-philosopher-king in Akbarian, Alexandrian, Platonic, and Solomonic terms, and which dwells at greater length on the *B* as cosmogonic agent.⁴⁷

Perhaps, then, we should begin to read celebrated kabbalists like Pico, Alemanno, Dee, and Bruno—philosophers of jazz—as Jewish or Christian Ibn Turkas. Their synthesizing, creative, subversive, and indelibly Pythagorean meditations on the Arabic, Hebrew, and Greek letter *B* are at the heart of Western metaphysics and physics alike, and deserve comparative investigation by historians of science, empire, and the book as such.

4 Note on the Text

The *R. al-Bā'yya* is preserved in Iran in two known manuscripts: Tehran, MS Majlis 10196/13, ff. 122^b–124^a, copied in 828/1425 from a comprehensive *majmū'a* of Ibn Turka's works most likely copied by Sharaf al-Dīn 'Alī Yazdī himself, and wholly reliable and authoritative; and Tehran, MS Sipahsālār 2930/1, ff. 1^b–6^a, copied in 845/1441 from another, less comprehensive collection of

45 Melvin-Koushki, "The New Brethren."

46 See, e.g., Killeen, Kevin and Peter J. Forshaw (eds.), *The word and the world: Biblical exegesis and early Modern science*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2007; Håkansson, Håkan, *Seeing the word: John Dee and renaissance occultism*, Lund: Lund University Press, 2001; de León-Jones, Karen Silvia, *Giordano Bruno and the Kabbalah: Prophets, magicians, and rabbis*, New Haven: Yale University Press, 1997; Ogren, *The beginning of the world*.

47 Melvin-Koushki, "The New Brethren."

Ibn Turka's works. Since the latter manuscript has unfortunately been stolen in the meantime, as I found to my alarm when on site, the translation below is based on my edition of the Majlis 10196 copy, for which see my forthcoming *The lettrist treatises of Ibn Turka*. Stylistically, that this treatise is in Arabic makes it more technical and less prosimetrical than its Persian counterparts in the author's oeuvre, following his general procedure. As such, its ten sections are titled according to the epistemic and generic scheme organizing the *Mafāḥiṣ*, according to the pattern "*wajh^{un} x fī naẓmⁱⁿ x*." Thus, for example, section 5: *wajh ḥisābī fī naẓm dhawqī*, "a calculative aspect as to direct experience."



On the B (ب)

In the name of God, All-merciful, Ever-merciful.

After rendering praise to God, Lord of all creatures and Creator of His intimates among those who ponder the evidence of His manifest signs, and after invoking His blessings upon him in whose niche of prophetic Sealhood and through whose perfect words appeared that which was hidden of the supernal realities from out their letter coverts, and upon his House and Companions, guides on the paths of certitude by means of their rational arguments and experiential allusions:

I chanced to meet an individual free of the vice of status-seeking whose noble aspiration impelled him to seek beyond merely posited significations and their circumscribed, improvised nutriment, which cannot satiate one's hunger on the quest for the meaning of celestial revelations and revelatory written forms; he asked me as to why the letter *B* opens the holy Quran and the nature of the characteristics it exclusively enjoys among the other letters which give it this precedence. I was initially hesitant to offer them my views on the subject given the intensity of his desire and the little I had to offer in the marketplace of composition—but then I came across the teachings of certain Sufis on the *B* that are detestable to any seeking guidance, given their use of baseless constructs and devious propagandizing, utterly devoid of edificatory value. The exigency of the moment therefore prompted me to give him but a taste of the various ripe fruits of the age pendulous on its highest branches and as yet unpicked.

Let me therefore present the matter in such a way as to be recognizable to those accustomed to the exoteric approach of the acquired, incremental sciences, thereby allowing those students with pure souls and quick minds to understand it:

The principles that inform the science of letters, despite the clarity of its method and the reliability of its arguments, appear recondite to most people. This is because the All-wise and All-knowing (whose wisdom is exalted) has distracted them from an evaluation of these principles in order to preserve the dignity of His inviolable might and out of solicitude for the majesty of His work, until time issues forth with the battle-standards of His rule.

[Now these principles are as follows:]

1. *A sapiential aspect as to the nature of Arabic*

Know that the letters have [certain natural] divisions that reveal those aspects which they share and in which they are distinct from one another. It is therefore necessary when plumbing their real meanings—which are free from the mediation of any artificial designation or positing by a designator or transmitter—to inquire into these aspects. For these meanings and the understanding of the same can only obtain from the letters themselves, whence the necessity of investigating the various aspects of their correspondences and characteristics essential to each letter individually according to the three forms they possess, from their points of articulation in manifestation to the disclosures of knowledge and perception, as has been shown at length elsewhere. What is clear [for our purposes here], however, is that this cannot be achieved without invoking the letters' abovementioned shared and distinguishing aspects, the former clarifying their [unitive] source in reality and the latter revealing their specific property according to how they may be used within the context of these divisions, both in the most explicit way possible. The purpose of my discourse having impelled me to instruct and inform [the reader] in a comprehensible way, I shall begin with [a list of] most of these aspects according to these divisions, rendering them the basis of our investigation here.

Thus: The letters include some that have an independent signification in common usage, this by way of convention, like *S* and *M*. Others have no such signification, except in compound with another [letter] of their namewords, like ' and §. First among the latter are those that only have this at the beginning of their namewords, like *B* and *S*. Others have it only at their end, like *H*. Still others have it only in their middle, like *Y* and *T*. Finally, there are the letters [whose namewords] have this signification completely, whether beginning, end, or middle, like *A*.

This principle being established, know that whatever has such a perfected terminus will have it arranged accordingly in those positions where it can occur. Such a position wherein [the letter] is enabled to achieve its terminal perfection requires its primordial reality and stronghold of essential receptivity, as with, for example, *B* and *S*, whose terminal perfection signifies [spir-

itual] meanings, which become most manifest when they initiate words and phrases.⁴⁸ As such, their primordial receptivity requires preeminence and firstness. The *B*, however, has a further signification as to how all things began—hence its being singled out to open the known [Quranic] text.

2. *A sapiential aspect as to inductive reasoning*

There is no offspring in the realms of contingency that is born and manifests on the pages of stripe and engendered being but that it is preceded by two parents or two premises, or the like among the various expressions of opposition according to the opposition of expressions. This is what is technically referred to as *the marriage act pervading all atoms*. From this it is manifest that duality has precedence over everything in natural terms, since it is not possible for a thing to manifest, whether epistemologically or essentially, without its being preceded by duality. It is precisely this that is the meaning form of the *B*, which has precedence as such.

3. *A discursive aspect as to direct experience*

Among the categorizations revealing aspects of the particular characteristics of the letters is that dividing them into *high [letters] of light*, which are those revealed by their own names in separate fashion at the beginning of the Quranic Sūras relating to the Sealing of prophethood, and *low [letters] of darkness*, which are those revealed only according to their referents in the constructions and words [of normal language]; both divisions are equal in number and balance each other as opposites.⁴⁹ [By this principle], it is clear that the *A* has preeminence within the first group, while *B* has preeminence in the second, and so is perfectly fitted to open the written and arranged [Quran] that people are familiar with.

But you may ask: How can it be fitting for a dark [letter] to open [the Quran] rather than a light one, given the latter's special association with transcendent holiness and nobility?

I answer: In the written Quran circulating among the public in book form are two orders of arrangement. The first is the primordial, holy, revelatory one, according to which He originally revealed it to His servant the Seal (God bless and keep him), who himself said that the first [verse] to be revealed to him was

48 Note that *B* opens the Quran and *S* closes it. By contrast, the Torah, which also opens with *B*, closes with *L*; these letters reversed give the word *lev* (= Ar. *lubb*), 'heart,' the focus of much kabbalistic speculation.

49 That is, the light letters are the *muqatta'āt*, representing half the Arabic alphabet, and the dark letters the remaining half.

the saying of the Most High “Read (*iqra*’ = *AQR*)” in the name of your Lord Who created!” [Q 96:1]. The second is arbitrary, conventional, and intermixed, and is that agreed upon by the Companions during the tenure of ‘Uthmān (God be pleased with him); its order was determined according to the lower letters. It is therefore clear that the order of the written [text of the Quran] that people are familiar with is the second one, and so the only letter fit to open it is the *B*—the same principle being likewise operative in the first order as to the preeminence of [the *A*, the letter] that was commanded to be recited at the very first.

4. *A verbal aspect as to exhortation*

The letters have another categorization, that according to their respective points of articulation. They include the labial [letters], which manifest from that point exclusively; the faucal-glottal, which manifest from that point; and the middling, which are uvular to dental. Among these divisions, the most manifest is of course the labial, especially when combined with a long vowel, as may be seen with the *B* (*bā*). Now it is clear that the fundamental point of the [Quranic text as so] written and arranged is to communicate and to manifest, nothing else—and foremost among all the letters competing for preeminence on the racecourse of making-manifest is the *B*, as you have been apprised; it wins that race.

5. *A calculative aspect as to direct experience*

The *second* [of anything] that is specifically described as such always refers to the *first* [of the same], which is what makes it second. This principle being established, it is evident that the *B* (= 2), for all that it refers to the Origin in the same way as all the other letters, at least in its external aural form—for speech as such necessarily presupposes a speaker—possesses a further indication of the Origin in its mental, [that is, mathematical,] form, complementing its external aural and visual forms. As such, the *B* contains within it [not just one but] two gates onto the first principle, unlike all the other letters, which makes it worthy of preeminence in the Speech of the Guide: for “God speaks the truth and He guides on the way” [Q 33:4].

6. *A written aspect as to direct experience*

Among the categorizations that explicate the realities of all the letters is that based on their dottedness: is their associated dot manifest or occult, above or below, and single or multiple? Now the dot is the form of distinguishing entification and the aspect of engendered existence; every letter therefore concentrates it, manifesting with it, making it singular, encompassing it, incorporating it into its own existential reality. Thus [the letter] becomes perfect in its ability

to refer to that desired as a necessary consequence of the manifestation of the aspects of correspondence between signifier and signified.

It is evident that the *B* comprises these aspects, unique [among the letters] in its placement of the dot below it, a single one. For as it has been said [by ‘Alī himself]: “*I am the dot beneath the B.*”⁵⁰ It is precisely the lower placement of the dot and hence the occultation of its properties that allows the letter to refer to absolute all-comprehensiveness [preceding delimited manifestation], of which there is no external form more perfect than the Quranic revelation. It is likewise evident that whatever letters are most explicit in their significations must be given precedence for the purposes of instruction and clarification—hence the precedence of the *B*.

7. Another written aspect in sapiential terms

Among the categorizations pertaining to the letter is that based on the [direction of] movement when writing it, which is the source of its manifestation. Some letters are produced by a descending, [vertical] motion of the pen from high to low, like *A* (ا), while others are produced by an extending, [horizontal] motion from right to left or the reverse. (This is the subset of this categorization that will concern us here; a full account of the various categorizations in all their significations may be found in [my *Book of*] *investigations*.) Supreme among the extending letters is the *B*.

Now the Quranic revelation, from the dawning horizon of its glad tidings to the noon terminus of its commands and the exposition of the figures of its lines, has various levels, whether general ones concerned with knowledge or differentiating ones concerned with revelation. [As that may be], all its levels were perfected through its manifestation to His servant Muḥammad (God bless and keep him). And it has further levels, to wit, those concerned with *extension*, given [his charge to] manifest and communicate it to all peoples. The most perfect and most manifest of all its levels among the general populace is the [Quranic] text as spoken and written, the one familiar to people. It is therefore necessary that [that letter] possessing precedence and preeminence in the [Quranic] text have supremacy in terms of extension, this in order to facilitate its communication and act as an instructive guide on the path. Hence it is necessary that the *B* open this text in its role as the most extended of the extensive letters.

⁵⁰ That Ibn Turka, departing from Ibn ‘Arabī, attributes this saying to Imam ‘Alī, may be inferred from his analysis of the same in *R. Nuqta*.

8. *A written aspect in mental terms*

When the descending motion whereby the *A* manifests is combined with the extending motion whereby the *B* manifests, their combination produces the *L*, which is the perfection of the revelation: for *ALM* has preeminence at the level of revelation. Given that the *L* is the most general expression of this form, and that the station of its textual recording and instructional arrangement requires differentiation whereby it may be distinguished, the *B* was made to open [the Quranic text], since it is the differentiating form of the *L*. Therefore do you see its form as fully spelled out to be the heart of the form of the *L*:



FIGURE 9.2
B as L

9. *A mental aspect as to exhortation*

It is evident from the above aspect that the father [or progenitor] takes precedence with respect to differentiating manifestation. But the precedence of the *L* has to do with the general and still occult [aspect] of the same. For as it has been sung:

My mother birthed my father—
a marvel among marvels!⁵¹

The first characteristic is possessed rather by the *B*, and the latter by the *M*. Therefore just as the *M* takes precedence over its two brothers at the level of general revelation, so too does the *B* take precedence at the level of differentiating textualization, in accordance with the principle of the balancing of opposites, as will be evident to the intelligent.

10. *Another mental aspect as to calculation*

The realities either pertain to the multiplicity of the [divine] Names or to the essential [divine] Oneness; there are no other poles than these two that may be signified or indicated. Now it is evident that the terminus of multiplicity is the *A*, in the same way that the form of Oneness is 1. As for the *B*, some of its simpler occult folds signify both of these poles, and it so merits precedence whenever the discourse relates to communication and instruction: for giving precedence to the general significance of what is intended is here required, as is evident.

⁵¹ This line is variously attributed to al-Ḥallāj or Imam ‘Alī.

As to how it signifies this, it is immediately evident upon the calculation of the name of its numerical value in clear Arabic, as may be seen from the following figures:

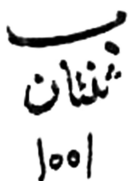


FIGURE 9.3
The value of the word "two"

11. *A further mental aspect as to calculation*

The *A*, which has precedence in every [other] comprehensive or specific arrangement, has a general form, which is that of its referent, as well as other distinguishing and differentiating forms according to the differentiation of its aspects, whether manifest or occult. The first of these forms is therefore $A (= 1)$, whose very form expresses its signified; among its forms that reveal its reality is [the Quranic construction] *In the name of* (بِسْمِ), [wherein the *A* is elided]. Thus you see its division by 2 and its multiplication by 2 resulting in the same [equation], which is the [mathematical] relationship that best shows the nature of its object and is operative in all its parts; this is because the same relationship is one of likeness and similitude, which does not give onto any aspect of ambiguity with respect the subject of its likeness, as is evident. Whoever wishes for a proof testifying to this principle, let him consider these figures:



FIGURE 9.4
The values of *A* and of *A* plus 1, which equals *In the name of*

Let this be the final point I raise in this treatise as to the aspects of the letters. May God Most High increase us in awareness of the intricate occult folds of the [Quranic] verses and grant us success in explicating such occult matters—this through the sanctity of him whose noble name has sealed the treasurehouses of perfection, Muḥammad, God bless and keep him and all his House.

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